Narrative reference

Story Bible

Theme, the rules of the debt, character arcs and the series structure. Every episode document must agree with this one.

Status	Source of truth for story decisions
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01 Logline and Theme

> **LOGLINE**
> A young woman who abandoned her family comes home for a funeral and discovers that her uncle has signed her life over to an ancient land spirit in his son's place. She has seven nights to break the pact, or pay it.

1.1 Theme: what we owe the land and each other

Everyone in this story takes something they have not paid for. The game asks whether a debt can be ended by giving back rather than by sacrificing someone else.

Who takes	What they take	How the story answers it
Chea (1910)	His children's lives *and* a fortune, from the guardian of the land	His descendants pay with their lives.
The French company (1923)	The forest, the shrine and the labour of its workers, without honouring any of them	By 1932 the estate is failing and lost in fog: the land is taking it back.
Sok (1931)	Sora's life, to save his son's	It costs him his own life, and leaves Sora the burden.
Sora (before 1932)	Her freedom, by abandoning her family and its past	She must come home and carry what she ran from.
Vuthy (1932)	His safety, at Sora's expense	He must choose to stand beside her and accept the risk.

The **true ending** is the only outcome in which nobody takes from anybody: Sora and Vuthy give their own blood, and the family gives back the fortune that was never theirs.

1.2 How the theme appears in each episode

Episode	Question it asks
1 · The House of Mourning	What do we owe the dead?
2 · The Whispering Pagoda	Can we be honest about what our ancestors did?
3 · The Drowned Village	Is it ever right to save one person by sacrificing another?
4 · The Rubber Plantation	What happens to those who take without paying?
5 · The Sunken Sanctuary	Will you give back, or let someone else pay?

02 The Rules of the Debt

These rules are fixed. Every scene, puzzle and ending must obey them.

#	Rule	Detail
1	**The price**	In return for saving Chea's children and giving the family prosperity, the guardian takes one life from each of four generations of Chea's bloodline. People who marry in (Yay Mey, Sora's father) are not of the bloodline.
2	**The schedule**	Each payment is taken when the guardian chooses. The fourth falls due one full twelve-year cycle after the third: Kanha died in 1920, so it falls due in 1932.
3	**The names**	The name of each person to be taken is written on the Golden Inscription Slab at the guardian's seat on Phnom Kulen. The fourth name was originally **Vuthy**, the eldest of the fourth generation.
4	**Changing a name**	A name can be changed by a ritual using earth from the shrine where the pact was made and the blood of the person making the change. Whoever does it loses the guardian's patience: the next offence against the pact will kill them. Sok did this in 1931.
5	**The seals**	Five consecrated objects bind the pact. **Only the named debtor can break them.** Anyone else who tries breaks a rule of the pact. Sok tried on Night 1 and died.
6	**The seven nights**	An attempt on the seals wakes the guardian and calls the debt due. It will collect on the **seventh night**, the night of the seventh-day funeral rites, at dawn. Before then it is bound by its own contract and will not take the named debtor.
7	**Other spirits**	The guardian does not command the Pret, the drowned spirit or the forest mimics. They are drawn by the festival of the dead, by grief and by the wakened debt, and they *can* kill Sora (the fail state).
8	**The paid dead are bound**	Each person taken stays bound to the place they died until the pact ends: Kanha at the clinic, Chea and Chhun as memories in the guardian's seat. They can be released early by a full rite of release.
9	**The gate**	The waterfall gate on Phnom Kulen opens only for the named debtor. Once all four elemental shrines are lit, the sanctum is open to **anyone of the bloodline**, which is how Vuthy reaches the altar.
10	**Severance**	With all five seals broken, the named debtor may sever the pact at the altar: thread and incense at the four corners, the true counter-mantra, and her own name redrawn on the slab in ink mixed with her blood, freely given.
11	**Judgement**	The guardian accepts the severance only if the bloodline has shown **respect**: honouring the dead, keeping taboos, telling the truth. If it is not satisfied, it treats the offering as a payment instead.

#	Rule	Detail
12	**The unsatisfied guardian**	When it treats the offering as a payment, it takes the **first name written** for the fourth generation: Vuthy's, still faintly visible under Sora's. This is the bitter ending, and the reason Vuthy is afraid.
13	**Shared blood**	If two of the last generation redraw their names together, freely, the debt is closed for the whole line and nobody is taken.
14	**Taking back**	When the pact is severed, "the guardian takes back what it gave": the family's land and fortune return to the earth. If it is fulfilled by a death, the family keeps everything.
15	**Failure**	If the counter-mantra is broken (too many wrong verses), the severance fails outright and the guardian takes the named debtor, Sora. This is the bad ending.

03 Characters and Arcs

3.1 Sora (សូរ៉ា), 24

Wants	To survive, end the curse and go back to her life in Phnom Penh.
Needs	To stop running from her family and accept that she belongs to it.
Flaw	She abandoned them. After her father's death in 1929 she stopped answering Yay Mey's letters, missed every memorial for her mother, and told herself the village and its beliefs had nothing to do with her. A bundle of those letters, unopened, sits in her studio drawer in the prologue.
Gift	She draws what she cannot say. Her mother Kanha drew too; the betel-tray drawing in Episode 1 is Kanha's. The sketchbook is how Sora understands the world, and in the finale she redraws the contract with her own hand.
Arc	Outsider (Ep 1) → listener (Ep 2) → betrayed daughter (Ep 3) → alone and angry (Ep 4) → the one who gives back (Ep 5).
Defining line	"I spent years pretending none of you were mine. I'm not doing that tonight."

3.2 Supporting characters

Character	Want and fear	Arc and payoff
Uncle Sok ឪសុខ	Wanted to save his son. Feared becoming the man who let another family member die, as he let Kanha die.	Chose Sora, then tried to undo it and died. Heard through his gramophone recording and seen in memories. Final memory in the Fire trial: "Forgive me, or don't. But finish it."
Yay Mey យាយមី	Wants to keep what is left of her family. Fears burying another grandchild.	Knew Sok had renamed the debt and stayed silent to protect Vuthy, whom she half raised. She told Vuthy after Episode 1. Confesses to Sora by telephone at the start of Episode 4. In the true ending she holds both grandchildren.
Vuthy វុទ្ធី	Wants to live. Fears that Sora will fail and the guardian will take him, the first name written (rule 12). Also supports his late mother's family on the family's money.	Sabotage (Ep 3) → companion, then betrayal (Ep 4) → saved or not → stands beside Sora or doesn't (Ep 5). His arc runs from fear to courage.
Kanha កញ្ញា	Bound at the clinic since 1920; wants to see her daughter one last time.	The drowned spirit. Freed by Sora (or not) in Ep 3; her voice guides the Water trial if freed.

Character	Want and fear	Arc and payoff
The Neak Ta ម្នក់តា	Wants the contract honoured, whether by payment or by a fair severance.	A judge, not a monster. Bows in the true ending.
Pa Lok	Wants to atone for rowing Kanha to the clinic in 1920.	Lends the boat, rescues Sora, gives her his compass.
Venerable Sophal	Wants the family to face its debt honestly.	Explains the seals (rule 5) and the importance of truth (rule 11).
Jean-Luc	Wanted profit; dismissed the workers' warnings about the shrine.	The mirror of Chea: took from the land without paying. Left the failing estate in 1929, ill. His ledgers explain the shrine and rule 12.

04 Series Structure

Story beat	Episode	What happens to Sora
Setup	1 · House of Mourning	Comes home reluctantly; learns of the pact; finds her own name.
Rising action	2 · Whispering Pagoda	Faces her ancestors honestly; begins to belong.
Midpoint twist	3 · Drowned Village	Lives the memory of Sok renaming her; meets her mother.
Dark night	4 · Rubber Plantation	Betrayed by Yay Mey's silence and Vuthy's fear; must decide whether to save him anyway.
Climax	5 · Sunken Sanctuary	Gives back.

05 How Each Truth Is Revealed

Show, don't tell: major reveals are **played or heard**, not read. Documents add detail for players who look for it.

Truth	Ep	How the player experiences it
Sora abandoned her family	1	The unopened letters in her studio drawer; Yay Mey's quiet reproach at the tent.
The pact and the seven nights	1	Sok's voice on a gramophone record.
Sora is named	1	The slip of names in the chest.
What Chea really asked for	2	Playable flashback as Chea.
Sok renamed the debt	3	**Playable memory as Sok** in 1931: the player scrapes Vuthy's name and writes Sora's.
The spirit is Kanha	3	Her face in the water; her lullaby.
Yay Mey knew	4	Her telephone confession.
Why Vuthy is afraid	4	His own words in the cellar, confirmed by the overseer's notes (rule 12).
Each generation's story	5	Memories at the end of each trial.

06 Timeline

When	Event
1910	Famine and cholera in a Kampong Cham forest village. Chea makes the pact at the Neak Ta shrine. Days later he is taken (payment 1).
1911	The family moves to rich land in Battambang. Chhun is taken (payment 2).
1912	Yay Mey entrusts the silver betel box to the village pagoda.
1920	Kanha drowns in childbirth at the Tonle Sap clinic where Sok is the medic (payment 3). The clinic is abandoned. Rith takes Sora, 12, to Phnom Penh.
1923	The rubber company clears the forest and builds its factory over the shrine.
1928	Sok visits the estate and fails to reach the cellar.
1929	Rith dies. Sora stops answering Yay Mey's letters. Jean-Luc leaves the failing estate.
1931	Sok returns to the clinic and renames the fourth payment from Vuthy to Sora. Yay Mey learns of it.
1932 · Night 1	Sok tries to burn the Bronze Token and dies at 8:12 PM. The guardian wakes; the debt is called due.
Nights 3–7	Episodes 1–5.

07 Consistency Checklist

Question a player might ask	Answer
Why can't Sok break the seals himself?	Only the named debtor can (rule 5).
Why seven nights, and why now?	The fourth payment is due in 1932 (rule 2); Sok's attempt called it due on the seventh night (rule 6).
Why doesn't the guardian just take Sora early?	It is bound to collect only on the appointed night (rule 6).
Then what can kill Sora before Night 7?	The other spirits (rule 7).
Why is Vuthy afraid if he is no longer named?	An unsatisfied guardian takes the first name written (rule 12).
How does Vuthy reach the altar?	The sanctum opens to the whole bloodline once the shrines are lit (rule 9).
Why does the family lose its fortune in the true ending?	Severance takes back what was given (rule 14).
Why is Kanha's spirit at the clinic?	The paid dead stay bound where they died (rule 8).
Why isn't Yay Mey in danger?	She married in and is not of the bloodline (rule 1).

STILL OPEN

- What happened to Kanha's baby in 1920?
- Confirm with the cultural advisor that the guardian's role as judge, the seventh-day rites and the blood-and-ink offering are respectful.